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## Location: where does it take place (learning environment)

This page explores various types of learning environments—each with its own advantages and disadvantages. Of course, final choice of location is up to your team.

In transdisciplinary education, two type of environments are involved: that of the higher education institution (education and research) and that of external partners such as the professional field and society. Determine together how these environments are interconnected, as this influences what and how people learn and work in transdisciplinary education. In general, you can choose from the following learning environments (Bouw, 2020; Bos et al., 2024):

Carrying out transdisciplinary education within an educational location has the advantage that the spaces are well-equipped with materials for working, learning, and collaborating. Think of projectors, screens, tables, chairs, and Wi-Fi. Moreover, the location is accessible and familiar to students, which can lower the barrier to participation. For societal partners, however, the campus might lie outside their comfort zone.

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Choosing an external location can be inspiring. In this setting, you have the space to experiment, research, and collaborate, often with societal partners already involved in the location. Additionally, it breaks the routine of a familiar environment. It can be a neutral space where all participants are and feel equal.

Consider the context carefully. What kind of environment do you want to create? Should it be informal, practical, or social? The choice depends on the complex problem you are addressing.

**At the example of Avans University of Applied Sciences**, HELIOs provide an external environment aligned with the complex issues that the education addresses. For example, the food garden Kleine Aarde focuses on issues like food transition, biodiversity, and soil health. Meanwhile, Buurthuis WijWest tackles social problems such as neighborhood loneliness or youth crime.

These and other learning environments are called HELIOs: physical places outside the walls of educational institutions where education, research, the professional field, and the community (such as neighbourhood residents) meet and collaborate. Within a HELIO, everyone is equal. It is a place to learn, research, and create together with others. More information and examples of HELIOs can be found in [this special magazine](#) [Dutch].

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The video [in Dutch] below shows an example of a HELIO taking place at Fort Isabella:

Another example of a hybrid transdisciplinary education location is the Marineterrein in Amsterdam:

- Learning environments based on **alignment**: learners move back and forth between the context of education and environments outside of education. With targeted interventions such as preparation exercises, follow-up days, and guidance meetings, you ensure alignment between education and the external context.
- Learning environments based on **incorporation**: integrate part of the educational context into the external context or vice versa. For example, at an educational location, you can practice in a simulated setting. In the external context, you can follow just-in-time theoretical education or practice skills with guidance.
- Learning environments based on **hybridization**: parts of the educational context and the external context come together in such a way that a new practice emerges, featuring characteristics of both contexts.